Virginie shook her head. “You can’t take all the risk for me. It’s not fair.”

“I can for Paulette. She needs you to protect her. Who knows when the war will be over? Rose and I are adults; we can look after ourselves.”

“No.” She looked down at her hands. “Édouard wouldn’t want that.”

“Yes, he would. My sister and I are returning the debt we owe you for taking us in after we were kicked out of the boardinghouse.”

“This is black market smuggling.” She leaned forward, taking Léa’s hand. “If you’re caught, the consequences could be prison or worse.”

Léa knew there was no other way.

The front door opened and the sound of footsteps racing over the stone floor echoed through the hall.

“Maman,” Paulette ran to embrace her mother. “Rose picked me up from school! We sang my favorite song the whole way back.”

Virginie lifted her daughter up on her lap. “Isn’t that lovely. Let’s go wash your hands and get you a *goûter*. There might still be a half slice of apple tart left, then you can start your homework.”

“After I finish, can I help Rose?” Paulette pointed at the table with the silver platter.

“Yes, you can. Come along now.” Virginie smiled at Rose, who had just entered the room. “Thank you for collecting Paulette. I’ll bring an extra mug. There’s more tea in the pot and it should still be warm. Paulette and I will be in the kitchen so that you and Léa can talk.”

Rose glanced at her sister, who was staring at her lap. Virginie placed her hand on Léa’s shoulder on her way out. “Thank you.”

“Where is Édouard?” Rose asked.

Léa shook her head. “There’s something I need to tell you.”

Rose sat down, and Léa told her what had happened to Édouard and the plan she had talked of with Virginie.

Rose sat still in the chair, listening without saying a word. Finally, Léa leaned forward. “Will you help?”

“Of course.” She took a breath. “It’s just . . .”

“What?”

“Keep me out of the tunnel. You know how I hate cramped spaces. Promise?”

“I promise. You won’t need to go in the tunnel. I’ll do that part.”